The construction of the road was not a major engineering feat, for there were no culverts or bridges required; just the blasting of rocks and the clearing of debris. However, having constructed the road, the Chinese now had to station troops to protect it.

It was estimated that one infantry division would suffice to meet any threat that might develop from the Indian side. Small roads were then made to connect their forward outposts, which ensured that apart from being well supplied, they were also linked by road to their headquarters at the rear.

As part of their overall policy, the Chinese also adroitly set about working on the local populations; they knew there had been boundary disputes between Tibet and Sinkiang to the north of the Karakoram Range. To appease the people of Sinkiang, a large tract of Tibetan territory north of the Kongka Pass–Lanak-la line was granted to them while political officers went around the Muslim population working up anti-Hindu sentiments against the Indians. Historically, there had been plenty of hostility between Tibet and Ladakh. A large number of Tibetan youth were therefore conscripted into the Chinese PLA and these units were deployed from Kongka Pass southwards, extending up to the Demchok Sector, where it was known that only Ladakhi troops were stationed.

For the security of the Sinkiang-Tibet road, the Daulat Beg Oldi Sector that lay to the west of Aksai Chin and south of the Karakoram Pass was extremely important. To the south of Aksai Chin were two massive brackish water lakes—the Pangong and Spanggur Tso—and the Indians had an airfield at Chushul next to the Spanggur Gap which allowed them to ferry men, equipment, ammunition and even heavy armament right up to the front lines. In the Chushul Sector, despite the Indian airfield, the Chinese were still at an advantage as a motor road to Rudok, a major military base, linked it to Tibet.

The Chinese plan was simple—as soon as the road network was completed, a series of outposts were to be established, reinforcing the existing positions. These posts were manned by Chinese Frontier Guards, irregular troops, who were given the task of probing the area ahead of them and occupying the dominating physical features in their area. If the need to cross the existing border arose, they were to do so but were to keep the commanders in Sinkiang and Gartok informed.

Prior to the Chinese attack in October 1962, the Chinese deployment opposite Nubra and Ladakh was divided into four sectors. The Northern